

MERIDIAN INTELLIGENCE

What the Paint Group Brief Would Have Cost the Traditional Way

Reference: UH Paint Buying Group Validation Brief, delivered 14 July 2026 | **Prepared:** 20 July 2026 | Confidential

The like-for-like scope

The brief delivered on 14 July was a desk-based strategic feasibility study: market and international analogue research (ALLPRO, NMBS, Topline, PaintWell), competition law framework mapping, a three-scenario financial model with break-even analysis, operating and rollout design, risk assessment, and a claim-by-claim source appendix. Advisory firms sell this exact product; BDO Ireland lists "Feasibility Studies & Market Research" as a named service line.

Guide cost and time from a traditional advisory firm

Element	Basis (assumptions labelled)
Engagement team	Partner oversight; director or senior manager leading; one analyst
Indicative day rates	Partner €2,500-3,500; director €1,800-2,500; manager €1,200-1,800; analyst €600-1,000. Benchmark-anchored assumption: published European Big Four partner rates run €3,000-5,000/day, with mid-tier firms below that band
Effort	25 to 40 consulting days across research, modelling, drafting, QA and partner review (assumption from workstream count)
Guide fee	€35,000 to €65,000 + VAT at a mid-tier firm; €50,000 to €100,000+ at a Big Four firm. Published guidance places comprehensive feasibility studies at \$10,000-\$50,000+, exceeding \$100,000 for complex engagements; a group of United Hardware's scale commissioning a new business line prices at the upper bands
Elapsed time	6 to 10 weeks: scoping and engagement letter (1-2 weeks), build (4-6 weeks is the published standard for a comprehensive study), internal QA and partner sign-off

The comparison

	Traditional advisory firm	Meridian Intelligence (as delivered)
Fee	€35,000-€65,000 + VAT (guide, mid-tier)	Delivered as a demonstration
Elapsed time	6-10 weeks	Same day , from CEO WhatsApp to verified document
Verification	Firm's internal quality review	Five parallel AI specialist passes; second-model challenge pass; full hostile review by an independent external AI system; corrections incorporated and logged
Traceability	Report with references	Claim-by-claim source appendix; every figure tagged verified, reported or assumption; append-only audit trail
Honesty of status	Typically presented as final	Explicitly labelled validation-ready, with seven named gates before any launch decision

Stated fairly

A commissioned firm study would add two things the demonstration brief deliberately did not include: primary fieldwork (retailer and supplier interviews) and firm-branded professional cover. That is precisely the point of the recommended 6 to 8 week validation sprint: the desk phase that would have consumed the budget and two months arrived in a day, so the spend goes where it earns, into the fieldwork that converts a credible concept into a bankable decision.

Figures are benchmark-anchored guide ranges prepared for internal decision-support, not quotations from any firm. Sources: BDO Ireland service listing (bdo.ie); consultfees.com 2026 benchmarks; consultancy.org fee tiering; simplefeasibility.com 2026 pricing guide. A single informal indicative quote from an advisory firm would convert the fee range to a verified figure.

